



ROUTEUP CAREER GUIDANCE SERIES — VOLUME 2

Choosing Your Country

The Honest Comparison Nobody Shows You

Ganesh Yenugandhula • Founder, RouteUp Career Hub • July 2026

Why This Decision Comes First

Most students choose a country the way they choose a movie — by what everyone around them is watching. Then they force the course, budget, and career to fit that choice. This volume reverses the order: your profile chooses the country, not the other way around.

Myth: “There is one best country, and it's the one my friends are going to.”

Reality: Every country is a different trade-off between entry difficulty, settlement certainty, earnings versus cost, and quality of life. The best country for your friend with ₹60 lakh family savings and an IT degree is often the wrong country for you.

Myth: “If I can get a visa, I should go.”

Reality: Getting in is one of four questions, and the least important. Australia refused about 40% of Indian student visa applications in early 2026, and the US refused over 60% of F-1 applicants from India in 2025 — but even a granted visa to the wrong country costs lakhs more than a rejection.

Myth: “I can decide the country later — first let me prepare IELTS.”

Reality: Backwards. IELTS requirements, budgets, intakes, and even which test is accepted differ by country. Choose the destination shortlist first, then prepare for its exact requirements.

The Honest Country Snapshot (July 2026)

USA

- Highest salaries and the world's deepest tech market — but F-1 refusal rates for Indians exceeded 60% in 2025, the H-1B lottery now favours senior high-paid roles, and Indian-born applicants face decades-long green card waits. A strong choice for master's students with excellent funding and profiles; a weak lottery ticket for everyone else.

Canada

- Still the clearest study → work (PGWP up to 3 years) → PR pipeline. But refusal rates for Indians run high, PGWP now demands stronger language scores, and Express Entry is being reformed to favour higher-wage occupations. The 2021-era 'easy Canada' no longer exists — it rewards planned profiles now.

UK

- Graduate route currently gives unsponsored post-study work, reducing to 18 months from January 2027 — factor this into any 2026-27 intake. Skilled Worker sponsorship needs roughly £41,700 or the going rate. World-class 1-year master's degrees, but a hard job market at the moment.

Australia

- Excellent quality of life and points-based PR that belongs to you, not an employer. But scrutiny is at a 21-year high: ~40% of Indian applications refused under the Genuine Student requirement, and the 485 post-study visa fee roughly doubled to A\$4,600 with a tightened age limit of 35 for most streams.

Germany

- Near-free public university tuition, 12–18% refusal rates (lowest of the majors), and the Opportunity Card lets even non-students come to search for jobs. The honest price: the German language. Without it, careers and PR move slowly. With it, Germany is the most underrated option on this list.

New Zealand & others

- NZ: quality option, new FTA benefits arriving — but the working-holiday route for Indians is not open yet; beware anyone selling it. Netherlands/Ireland: strong English-speaking niches. UAE/Singapore: high savings, weak settlement tracks.

What consultancies won't tell you: many push whichever country pays them the highest commission for that intake, not the one that fits you. If a counsellor recommends a country before asking about your budget, academics, and 10-year goal — that recommendation is about their income, not your future.

Worksheet — Score Yourself Before Choosing

For each shortlisted country, answer honestly:

- ☐ Can I get in? — Do I meet the academic, English, and financial requirements TODAY, with a 20–30% funds buffer above the official minimum?
- ☐ Can I stay? — What exactly is the post-study visa called, how long is it, and what must I do during it to qualify for the next stage?
- ☐ Earnings vs cost — What is a realistic graduate salary in MY field there, and what is the real monthly cost in the city I'd live in?
- ☐ Will I be happy? — Climate, distance from family, community, work culture: have I spoken to one real person living there (not an influencer)?
- ☐ My top 2 countries after scoring: _____
- ☐ The single biggest doubt I cannot resolve alone:

When to Get Help

Everything in this volume you can act on yourself — that is deliberate. But the worksheet you just filled has answers only YOU could write, and validating those answers against real requirements, real budgets, and real immigration rules is where mistakes hide.

Bring your completed country scorecard to session with RouteUp. We will go through it line by line and tell you honestly — including if your plan is fine and you don't need us further.

Book your free session: www.routeup.co.in · hello@routeup.co.in ·

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